

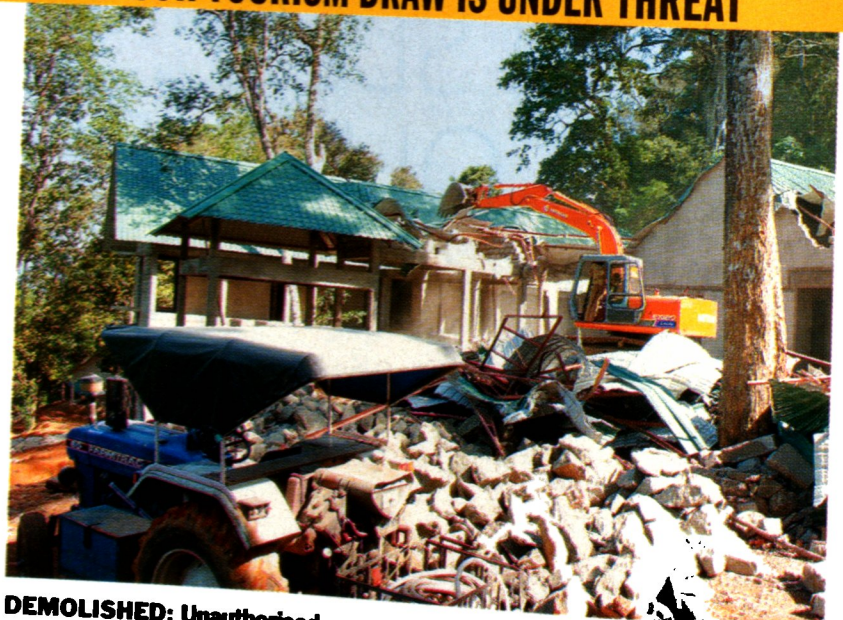


SUN BURNT: Tourists share space with stray dogs attracted by refuse district. About a hundred buildings, including major resorts, were razed to the ground for alleged violation of construction laws. Though the drive had noble intentions, the tourism industry caused them a major setback. Yet Kerala continues to be India's hottest tourism destination. In the first six months of this year, domestic and foreign tourist arrivals showed 7 and 20 per cent growth, respectively, and in this year's season that has just begun, most hotels and resorts are booked till April. Statistics reveal that travellers from all over the world continue to hop on to Kerala-bound airplanes. Says the state tourism minister Kodyeri Balakrishnan, "We know there are problems and we have

THE DETERIORATION IS SO RAPID THAT AT ITS CURRENT RATE, THE STATE'S SUSTAINABILITY AS A MAJOR TOURISM DRAW IS UNDER THREAT

favoured tourism destination ever since Arundhati Roy immortalised it in her Booker-winning *God of Small Things*. Surrounded by exotic greenery and silent backwaters, the place is now a major construction site. More than 50 resorts of all categories, including five-star deluxe types, where a suite goes for more than Rs 45,000 a day during peak season, have come up here in the past decade. Environmentalists say this frenetic activity has caused much damage to the fragile wetland ecosystem which include mangroves and has led to the depletion of the bird population in the famed Kumarakom bird sanctuary. According to a study, the number of bird species here has come down from 189 to 66 in the past decade.

The breathtaking 200-sq-km Vembanad backwaters, one of the largest in the country, faces many threats like heavy silting, growth of weeds and plastic pollution. "Unless emergency measures are undertaken, Vembanad backwaters will die since silting, plastics and weeds have reduced the depth of waters to barely five-six ft in many places," warns T. Damu, vice-president, Taj Group and member of the advisory panel in the ministry of tourism. It is only now that the resort people have realised that ecological degradation would kill the



DEMOLISHED: Unauthorised structures in Munnar have been razed industry and have united to initiate actions to protect the environment.

Kerala's hill stations have also witnessed a phenomenal rise in unauthorised constructions and encroachment into forests ever since the tourism boom began in the 1990s. Recently Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan took the initiative of demolishing all unauthorised constructions—mostly hotels and resorts—in Munnar, a hill station with large-scale tea plantations in Idukki

a comprehensive programme to tackle these." Of late, the government appears to have seen the writing on the wall. "Responsible Tourism" is the current theme of the state tourism department which has initiated a set of programmes to make the local community benefit from the tourism industry as well as check social or environmental decay. "We have to take care that the golden goose is not killed" says V. Venu, state tourism secretary. But at the current rate of degradation, it won't be long before the golden goose turns into a dead duck.

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